attacking Pakistan during the first phase of the crisis in January 2002. The Indian government's restraint during this period resulted primarily from the belief that its policy against Pakistan was succeeding. The Indians also feared that, having lost the advantage of strategic surprise, they would find the costs of a conventional confrontation with Pakistan excessively high.[94]

Pakistan's nuclear capability did play a role in stabilizing the second phase of the crisis, in May and June 2002. The existence of Pakistani nuclear weapons prevented the Indians from planning an all-out attack against Pakistan during this period. As former Indian army vice chief of staff V. K. Sood explains, "India could sever Punjab and Sindh with its conventional forces." However, "Pakistan would use nuclear weapons in that scenario." The Indians therefore sought "not to fight for real estate," but rather to "draw Pakistani forces into battle . . . and inflict damage from which Pakistan would take a long time to recover."[95] Thus Pakistani nuclear weapons did not prevent India from planning for a significant attack against Pakistan proper, but they did ensure that the attack's projected scope would be limited, so as not to threaten Pakistan with catastrophic defeat. Additional reasons for India's failure to attack Pakistan in mid-2002 were the loss of the element of surprise; concern with the costs of a large-scale Indo-Pakistani conflict, including the possibility of nuclear escalation; and a desire to avoid angering the United States by attacking America's key ally in the Afghan war.[96]

Most importantly, however, Indian officials decided not to attack Pakistan because they viewed the Parakram deployment as having been successful. No further terrorism on the scale of the Parliament attack had occurred during the crisis. And the Indians had secured a Pakistani pledge, backed by American promises, to prevent such violence in the future. Vajpayee explains that "America gave us the assurance that something [would] be done by Pakistan about cross-border terrorism. . . . America gave us a clear assurance. That was an important factor" in the Indian decision to demobilize.[97] Fernandes maintains that India had "no reason to attack." The Indians had "stayed mobilized to make the point that another [terrorist] attack would result in an immediate response. . . . No further attacks